

What we can answer, and what we'd need to ask for

Prepared 7 September 2026 by the Lunenburg Budget Project, an independent archive of the town and school budgets at lunenburgbudgetproject.org. Every figure quoted here is traceable to a document published on that site.

7 September 2026. Every answer below was tested against the documents we actually hold.

This is the plain-language version. It talks about **documents the town and the state publish**, because that is what an answer here ultimately rests on — not on anything about how we store them.

First: the one distinction that decides most of these answers

Four kinds of document, and they are not equally strong. Almost every "partly" below comes down to which one a figure came from.

1. The accounting system. The town's own books — every transaction, with what was budgeted, what was moved mid-year, what was spent, what is still committed. This is the strongest evidence there is.

We hold this for the schools for one year: FY2026, through 30 June. Plus one quarter of FY23, and the athletics revolving fund for three years.

2. The Town Accountant's year-end statements. The balance sheet and the schedule of special revenue funds, printed in each annual town report. Not the raw books, but prepared from them by the town's own accountant, and each one adds up to the totals it prints.

We hold thirteen years of these, and they are reliable.

3. The district's budget books. The school budget documents, which show next year's plan and also re-state what earlier years came to. That re-stated column is the district's own account of what it spent.

We hold twelve years. This is where most of our school spending history comes from — and it is the district describing itself, not an independent record.

4. The state's figures. DESE collects staffing, enrolment and spending from every district to its own definitions.

We hold seventeen years, FY2009–FY2025. This is independent in a way nothing else here is.

Why the third one keeps mattering. A budget book cannot show money being moved between lines during the year. Transfers get approved mid-year and never appear in it. So when the question is *did they spend it where they said they would* — that is precisely a question about mid-year movement, and only the accounting system records it.

Your three big objectives

ONE: WHY WAS THERE A SURPLUS, AND WHERE?

Which lines came in under plan — YES for FY2026, from the accounting system. That report shows, per account, what was budgeted, what was moved into or out of it during the year, and what was actually spent.

But "which lines" is not "what caused it", and I should not have let those run together. A line that came in under plan could be a post left vacant, a service that was cut, a grant that covered the cost instead, money moved to another line, or a line that was over-budgeted from the start. **Every one of those looks identical** — a smaller number in the spent column.

The accounting system narrows it: it shows mid-year transfers, so money moved to another line can be told apart from money not spent. That is genuinely more than a budget book gives you. It still cannot tell a vacancy from a cancelled service from a grant.

So: we can say **exactly where** the surplus sits, to the dollar, for FY2026. **Why** it sits there needs something else — the payroll detail for a vacancy, the grant records for a funding switch — and each of those is a separate request.

For FY2014–FY2025 — partly. We can show what the district *reports* it spent against what it planned, from its own budget books, for twelve years. That is worth having and it is not proof. It is their account of themselves.

What wasn't paid for that previously was paid — this is your strongest question and we can largely answer it. Twelve years of the district's own figures, line by line, shows every line that was funded and then wasn't, and when. It survives the weakness above, because it is a claim about what the district *reports* year on year — and their own book is a fair source for that.

Nothing has been built for it yet. It is the best page we could build next.

Where it gets harder: the district's line names don't map onto the town's accounting codes. The district names lines like *H.S. Guidance Counselor*; the town codes accounts by function. Nobody publishes the mapping between them, and we refuse to invent one.

And on their explanations: we can search everything the boards said from 2025 onward — about 1,400 documents. For anything earlier, we can measure what happened and cannot retrieve what was said about it at the time.

TWO: ARE THE SCHOOLS OVER-BUDGETING?

For FY2026 — yes, we can test it. The accounting system shows budget, mid-year movement and spending together.

Before FY2026 — no, not to a standard that would survive challenge. Both halves of the comparison come out of the same budget book. **A document cannot audit itself.** We can show a pattern in what the district reports, and we should — the same line coming in under plan eight years running is a budgeting practice, not an accident — but it must be labelled as their own reporting.

One thing to fix in how we ask it: *proposed* and *voted* are different numbers. Over-budgeting usually means "did they ask for more than they needed", which compares against what they **asked for**, not what town meeting approved.

All revenue for the whole town: for FY2026, yes, in full detail — every fee, permit and charge by department. For earlier years, partly: the annual reports list revenue by source, but some of those figures have been checked against the report's own totals and some have not, and the two cannot be added together.

Money outside the budget — yes, thirteen years, from the Town Accountant's schedules. That is already published on the site.

THREE: THE ALL-IN COST OF EACH LINE

No — and this one is structural rather than a gap in our archive.

A budget line is what the town has to **raise**, after grants, fees, state aid and the district's revolving funds have paid their share. It is not what the thing costs. To build an all-in cost you would need, for every line, the grants, the fees and the reimbursements that also paid for it — **and nobody publishes that mapping.**

The district's own budget workbook shows the problem: beside a transportation line, in the comments column, someone has asked whether that figure already reflects a reduction for expected bus fees. **The people writing the budget were not sure which of their own lines were net of what.**

What would close it: the state requires districts to file a year-end financial report that separates spending by funding source. That would give all-in cost **by category** — not line by line, but far better than nothing.

Your specific questions

How much on coaches, on athletic transportation, per year — partly, and I overstated this before. Six of the seven documents behind our athletics figures are budget documents. So we can say what the district *budgeted and reports* for thirteen years. What we have from the accounting system is the athletics **revolving fund** — three years of every transaction in and out. That is why we can say confidently what went into that fund and less confidently what the general fund paid out.

Have teacher counts changed — yes, seventeen years, from the state. Teaching staff has fallen from about 120 full-time-equivalent in 2009 to about 105 in 2025, while students placed outside the district rose from about 84 to 97 and total enrolment fell from 1,739 to 1,563. These are proper full-time-equivalent figures, not a count of names. **Nothing on the site says this yet.**

Has admin count changed — no. The state publishes administration *spending*, not administrator counts. The town prints staff lists by name in every annual report, fifteen years of them, but a list of names is not a staffing level: a part-time music teacher and a full-timer are one name each.

Grade-specific staffing trends — partly. The town's staff lists are per school, so you can separate primary from high school — but in names only. The state's full-time-equivalent figures have no grade breakdown. **You**

can have grade detail without FTE, or FTE without grade detail, and not both.

The special education paraprofessional question — much closer, not settled. Between 2018 and 2025 the district's reported spending on that line roughly doubled, while the state's count of paraprofessionals rose by about a third. **So more staff explains part of it and not all of it.**

It is not settled because the state counts *all* paraprofessionals and the budget line is special education only — different groups of people. And the remainder could be pay steps, more hours, reclassified roles, or a grant ending. The year-end financial report above would remove the grant explanation.

How many children leave the district each year — no. We have enrolment, which falls for many reasons: families moving away, smaller birth cohorts, school choice, charter schools. **A fall in enrolment is not a count of departures.** What would close it: the state's school choice and charter reports, which state how many children go where and what tuition follows them.

How many special education students — yes as a share, roughly as a count. The state publishes the percentage of students with disabilities each year: 14.7% in 2009, 15.8% in

1. Against current enrolment that is about 247 children — but that multiplication is

ours, not a published figure.

Separately, the annual reports give **out-of-district placements** for thirteen years, counted each 1 March and split into collaborative, day and residential. Those are children placed outside the district — a much smaller and different number.

Athletes and costs per sport — participations YES, costs STATED and disputed.

Participation by sport and season, and the fee schedule, hold up. Per-sport **costs** come from one document — the district's own workbook — nothing independent checks them, and the district has publicly given inconsistent answers about them. Report them as the district's figures, with that flag, and report the three-way disagreement beside them. See *"So what CAN we say about athletics costs?"* above for the full answer.

What would close it: the accounts-payable detail behind those warrants — the vendor and description for each payment — which the town's accounting system holds and does not publish.

How confirmed is an answer? Three levels — and all three are answers

TJ, first: *"can we actually PROVE it?"* Then, on my answer to that: *"I think we should be able to give some level of answer, but not a confirmed-with-invoice level of confirmed. Which IS an answer, just not to full detail."*

Both are right, and the second corrects an over-swing in the first. **A refusal is not more honest than a bounded answer — it is just less useful.** So the levels below are a label that travels WITH an answer, never a gate that withholds one.

LEVEL	WHAT IT MEANS	HOW TO SAY IT
Stated	A document says so, and nothing independent checks it	<i>"The district's workbook states..."</i>
Cross-checked	A second, independent document agrees — or visibly disagrees, which is itself informative	<i>"Two documents give X and Y, and they differ by Z"</i>
Traced to a payment	An invoice, warrant or payroll record. The transaction happened	<i>"The fund paid out X"</i>

Most of this project lives at Stated and Cross-checked, and that is normal for public records. Very little municipal information is traceable to a payment without a records request. The failure is not being at level 1 or 2 — it is *reporting* level 1 as though it were level 3.

One extra flag, above all three: where the body that produced a figure has publicly declined to stand behind it, say so beside the number. That is not a lower level; it is a different fact about the figure, and readers need it.

So what CAN we say about athletics costs?

Quite a lot, once the levels are attached rather than used to refuse:

Traced to a payment. The athletics revolving fund paid out **\$317,004 in FY2024**, \$293,054 in FY2025 and \$171,154 in FY2026. Those are real transactions. Split by kind — payroll, warrants, corrections — but **not by sport**: each payment carries a warrant number and no vendor, no description, and no sport, across three years.

Cross-checked, and they disagree — which is the finding. For FY2024 there are three figures for what athletics cost, from three documents:

the district's workbook states	351,643
the revolving fund actually paid out	317,004
the general fund carried	285,281

The first is a claim about total cost; the second and third are money that actually left two different pots. **The fund and the general fund together come to \$602,285 — well above the workbook's stated total** — and nothing published reconciles them. That disagreement is a solid, defensible finding on its own, and it is more useful than any single number.

Stated, and publicly disclaimed. Per-sport costs come only from the workbook, and School Committee minutes of 24 June 2026 record that questions about the actual cost of middle school athletics have received *"inconsistent"* answers. Report those figures as the district's, with that flag attached — do not repeat them as established, and do not suppress them either.

Solid at any level. Participations by sport and by season, and the fee schedule with the date each rate was set. Those are counts and rates, not costs, and they hold up.

So the answerable version of "what does middle school athletics cost" is: the district removed it as a budget reduction of **\$14,415**, community members have asked what it actually costs and received inconsistent answers, and available data raises the question of whether fees exceed the cost. **That is a real answer to a real question** — it just is not a cost figure, and nobody currently has one.

And the same for the surplus

Where it sits: to the dollar, for FY2026, traced. Which accounts came in under plan, and how much moved between lines mid-year.

Why it sits there: bounded, not settled. A line under plan can be a vacancy, a cut service, a grant covering the cost, a transfer out, or over-budgeting. All five look the same. The accounting system does separate one of them — money *moved* is distinguishable from money *not spent* — which is more than a budget book can do.

So the answer is: here is exactly where, here are the possible causes, here is the one we can rule in or out, and here is the document that would decide the rest. Not "we cannot say".

What I'd ask the Town for, given all this

Ranked by how much each would unlock:

1. **The year-end expense report from the accounting system, for the school department, for each year we want.** We already hold exactly this report for FY2026 — so we know it exists, we know what it looks like, and asking for prior years is a small request. **This single document turns the twelve-year over-budgeting question from "their account of themselves" into a real audit.**
 1. **The state's year-end financial report separating spending by funding source.** Closes the "is this line net of a grant" question that sits underneath the paraprofessional figures and the special education projection.
 1. **The school choice and charter sending reports.** Turns "enrolment fell" into "this many children left, and for where".
 1. **Staffing by budget line with full-time-equivalents.** Would let a dollar change be split into "more people" and "the same people paid more" — the question you asked and we still cannot fully answer.
 1. **The accounts-payable detail behind the athletics warrants** — vendor and description for each payment out of the revolving fund. Small, specific, and it is the only thing that would let anyone say what a sport actually costs. The district has said it does not know; this is the document that would tell them.
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Three pages worth building from what we already hold

1. **What stopped being funded** — every school line that went to zero or fell sharply, FY2014–FY2025, labelled as the district's own reporting.
2. **Teaching staff against out-of-district placements** — two state-published series, seventeen years, moving in opposite directions. Nothing says this.
3. **Which years are which** — a plain page showing which years of school spending we can evidence from the accounting system and which rest on the district's own account. Right now a reader has no way to tell, which is exactly how I got it wrong.